than that of RT-PCR tests. However, considering the benefits of sero surveillance, the ICMR cleared the way and imported rapid testing kits from two Chinese companies. India was one of the early recognizers of the usefulness of rapid antigen tests as a community health measure as early April as opposed to countries like the US, who came around to approving their use only in the month of May.[1] Even after these were approved, they weren't really used for mass surveillance. In fact, a popular American cardiologist, scientist and author Dr Eric Topol had been pushing for community surveillance as an effective measure to restrict the spread of the virus since the final weeks of March, however the US government didn't quite see merit in it like India did.[2]

Soon after, several local governments raised concerns over the accuracy of these kits. They complained that the accuracy of the received kits was only about 5 per cent, down from about 78 per cent. This meant that in a normal scenario, if rapid antigen kits were used on a hundred patients who were already tested COVID-19 positive on RT-PCR, 78 of them would turn up positive even on the rapid antigen testing kits. In the case of the five lakh, overpriced tests received from the two Chinese companies, not only did they fail ICMR's quality tests but also only five out of a hundred positive patients were testing positive. In other words, the tests failed to detect 95 per cent of positive cases, raising an alarm amongst the authorities. This wasn't the first time we had received faulty equipment from China and were certainly not the first or only country to encounter this problem. We had recently also received a faulty batch of 50,000 PPE gear from them. Spain, Czech Republic, Slovakia, Turkey and the UK had also received faulty test kits after paying millions of dollars to procure them. Due to these experiences, Georgia cancelled its agreement to procure the kits. The Netherlands also had a salty experience after being delivered about six hundred thousand N95 masks in which neither did the fillers work nor did they fit like they were supposed to. However, when the Dutch officials requested a recall, instead of apologizing, Beijing blamed the Netherlands asking the Dutch government to read the instructions on the box.[3]

The ICMR, needless to say, halted the use of these kits and cancelled the remaining order from the Chinese companies.[4] Not putting all our eggs in one basket, we began to source from South Korea, Germany, Canada and Japan. Taking forward the 'Make in India' initiative, SD Biosensor, a South Korean company manufacturing tests with a facility in Manesar, began